

Cimitero Monumentale for *provisional* burial in Toscanini's family tomb." And sugary cleverness or not, it was Toscanini who with fire and fanaticism first played the unfinished *Turandot*.

[Kenneth Connelly]

VENETIAN RED

At the beginning of the sixth chapter of P.M. Pasinetti's novel, *Rosso Veneziano*, we see Paolo Partibon, one of the protagonists, walking slowly through his house. He walks heavily up the wooden stairs to the wooden terrace, which, at sunset, looks out on a golden landscape of roofs, chimneys, and red clouds. His wife, Vittoria, is already upstairs in a curtained pavillion, embroidering flowers on silk. When Paolo has climbed to where the two are on the same level, a singular conversation begins between them. Vittoria says, "This Testa, this hunchbacked journalist. Telephoned again."

"He isn't hunchbacked," Paolo answers. "I don't know why you continue to say Testa is hunchbacked."

"For me he is," Vittoria adds.

We have here, captured in this scene and in the few words of this dialogue, one of the preliminary dimensions of the novel. It is a dimension that we have already defined (see Italian Quarterly III, 11, pp. 32 and 38) as a vision of the world seen from above. First we have Paolo who, as he walks slowly through his house, decomposes the objects in it, by an act of clever alchemy, into visual and olfactory sensations. For example, we experience a fusion of color and odor when he speaks of the odor of cigarettes kept in silver boxes. Combined in the same sensation we have the odor of the cigarettes, and the color of the silver boxes in which they are kept. Then there is Vittoria's intervention, in which the deformation of exterior reality is translated into a distortion of normal syntax. This distortion reproduces very well the arbitrariness of her violent caricature of Testa, and the tone and rhythm of the spoken language. For instance, there where we would have expected her to say, "Quel Testa, quel giornalista gobbo, ha telefonato;" she puts a period in the place of the comma dictated by normal syntax, and says "Quel Testa, quel giornalista gobbo. Ha telefonato." This brings us to the definition of one of the characteristics of the whole Partibon family, which includes Paolo, Vittoria, Elena, and Giorgio, and that is their utterly personal and exclusive manner of appreciation and participating in life. Their manners do not correspond to those of others, and they have a violent and dogmatic way of characterizing and defining the others with phrases that are often paradoxical and can be understood only from their own point of view. The conventional gestures of other people are anticipated, and the viewpoint from

which life is seen is slightly blasé. We are of course in a strongly traditional society here, where refusing to greet a person is the greatest punishment one can give him, and looking through a person as if he didn't exist is an art. But in Pasinetti's novel, naturally, we must look elsewhere for the causes of the snobbish hedonism of the family of protagonists. Pasinetti seems to want to say that the gestures of this great, aristocratic, Venetian society, its snobbism even, are its only way of reacting to the absurd world of pre-war Europe: a world, the majority of whose members are shouting and screaming, is opposed by a disdainful minority. The moral protest is made in gestures because no other means of expressing it exists. However, the celebration of this rite of a disdainful intelligence which shuts itself off from the exterior world occupies only a part of the novel, the first part. There are many beautiful pages describing the family scene in this part, such as those on the death of Grandmother Partibon. But there are two salutary crises that break the isolation of the ritual and give a dynamism to the whole story: the love of Elena for Ruggero, and Giorgio's voyage in search of the mysterious Uncle Marco. With Elena's love, life is transformed from an intelligent game into a moral and historical drama. The forbidden games of spoiled and overly-intelligent children become the forbidden games of a society and a country which sends its sons to their death in a stupid and criminal war.

The link between family life in Venice and Giorgio's trip is this mysterious Uncle Marco, who is very important to the development of the novel. He is the key that transforms family history into the history of a society and a country. Marco's rebellion is two-fold. It is both the rebellion of the triumphant personality who breaks the chains of family tyranny, and the rebellion against the native land which has ceased to be a country of justice. Marco is really the mirage of Giorgio's conscience, and it is the vague contours of his mysterious adventures which give Giorgio the desire to undertake a precise action and a real search. If Marco represents the precognition of the world's approaching catastrophe, Giorgio represents its discovery. This discovery in the novel has two stages: the trip to Rome and the trip to Berlin. Giorgio reveals for us the face of the enormous bureaucratic capital of fascism that is Rome, and his tour through the ministries of the city is a nightmare.

The visit to Berlin has a double aspect: the aspect of personal adventure — Giorgio in search of his cousin and his uncle; and an aspect more universally historical — the days of violence and the persecution of the Jews. But the two are unified by the fact that Manuela, Giorgio's cousin, is herself part Jewish. Giorgio's intervention is thus of an abstract, idealistic nature, but it is passionate as well. In the light of these events, his hatred of Bolchi,

who personifies the principle of evil in the book, also has a well-defined, concrete side to it. Throughout the novel Pasinetti has known how to alternate abstract images which create a nightmarish atmosphere with concrete, easily recognizable events.

The novel includes a family of politicians, the Fassolas, as well as the Partibon family of artists, but the Fassolas are not politicians in the sense that Bolchi is. If the Partibon family is aristocratic, the Fassolas are bourgeois parvenus. Their Machiavellianism stems from this social condition. For them, as Machiavelli said, activity consists in doing something, anything, even pushing a stone. This activity is their only way of being alive. They know no other way of living, since they lack the intellectual dimension completely. But they are authentic, real people, and for this reason not repugnant. They have another characteristic, however, that complicates their life, and that is the fact that they are close to the Partibons although they despise them; they hate them without being able to live without them. In this sense, Enrico, who loves Elena Partibon without hope, is the most pathetic character in the book. There is a gradation in the Machiavellianism of the Fassola family. Ermete, the government official, in whom intelligence and action are completely separated, does what he does and at the same time he judges the life around him, without letting this judgement intrude in any way on his action. Then there is his brother Augusto, whose intelligence is completely obscured, and who can be awakened from his dream of grandeur only by a shock, the death of his son. There is Massimo, who burns his life out in action. And finally, there is Enrico, for whom moral judgement and political action meet and mingle, completely destroying his efficiency as a politician, and making evident all his human weaknesses. These two family groups can also be seen as symbols of the two dimensions of the novel; the moralistic taste for contemplation and intellectual definition of the human condition; and the sense of movement and action, the transformation of morality into events. It is precisely these two aspects which make Pasinetti's novel so rich and interesting — so easy to read, because of its figurative visualization, and at the same time so subtle. The psychological penetration serves to give vitality to the many characters in the novel, to separate their personalities from the plot, from the richness of events and the amplitude of the landscape, and at the same time to transform the book from a novel of character to one of atmosphere. Those who have experienced fascism can feel this novel as a part of their life. Those who look to novels for stories of human beings finding and losing themselves, loving and hating, will find in this book of Pasinetti's a story of love, suffering, and life that they can not help enjoying. It is a rich book that must be read.

[D. D. T.]

SVEVO SURVEYED

After all these years and after so much critical debate it was inevitable, though tardily so, that a full-length book should appear on *Italo Svevo* (Nistri-Lischi: Pisa). Its author, A. Leone De Castris, has diligently plied the bibliographies of Bruno Maier, the *Vita di mio marito* of Livia Veneziani Svevo, and has of course meticulously read the rather slender corpus of Svevo's opera omnia. It is a generously proportioned book with two introductory chapters on the early life and influences, a long chapter on each of the three novels, a sort of inter-chapter on the Svevian "silence" between *Senilità* and *La coscienza di Zeno*, a chapter on Svevo's language, and two substantial appendices. With the fervor of a guide to unappreciated riches, Mr. De Castris conducts the reader through elaborate analyses that attempt to pay consistent attention both to "linguistic facts" and to the narrative structure. Most of the time he is content to explain the work as one would explain a piece of complex machinery; but every now and then he will suddenly announce that such and such a scene is "bellissima" or "stupenda." The reader may well sense a certain disproportion between analysis and evaluation. Certainly, he may often lose the drift of the argument in the midst of mere presentation of plot. Not that Mr. De Castris does not have greater ambitions: he attempts to characterize, by means of analyzing the fiction and the autobiographical utterances and by means of tracing influences, Svevo's whole outlook on life and art.

This is not so much a life-and-works book in the style of the French *thèse de doctorat* as it is a "spiritual biography." Perhaps it would have been improved if some of the merely conjectural assumptions, derived from ambiguous biographical information, had been entirely dispensed with. Too much is made, for example, of the bourgeois origins of Svevo. Surely in his novels Svevo presents us not with class criticism, but rather with an implicit criticism of all life. Mr. De Castris does restore some balance by insisting that Svevo is not a conventional propagandistic purveyor of "naturalism." But then the balance is upset by an insistence that Svevo somehow was solving his personal problems, moral and social, by writing, at least in *Una vita*, "a study — in a narrative key — of a reality, a concrete organism, in which he could assess that man whom his culture and his own sensibility have presented him with." We need more strictly biographical evidence to convince us that there is no confusion in Mr. De Castris' mind between *Dichtung* and *Wahrheit*.

After a competent and sympathetic description of *Una vita*, the book proceeds to analyze *Senilità*. Here Mr. De Castris attempts the sort of analysis which gives his book some claim to originality in Svevian studies: a demonstration in particular passages of the